TAKEAWAY

"I like to quote the late US poet-activist Maya Angelou: 'Every time a woman stands up for herself, without knowing it and without realising it, she stands up for all women'"

The Taboo Breaker

In Class 9, Aditi's science teacher, who made every other lesson easy and fun, skipped the chapter on menstruation entirely. "With a taboo subject, there is a hidden code that somehow everybody knows," she says of her small school in Garhwa, Jharkhand. It was the 1990s, and at home, too, the rules were unequivocal. "I grew up looking at myself as something dirty and impure. No going to the puja room. No touching things in the kitchen," recalls Aditi.

Her worldview changed at the National Institute of Design, when she met Tuhin Paul who was her project partner, and is now her husband. What began as a classroom exercise became their diploma project, then a funded research project. The duo chose the comic book format deliberately. "The medium is the message. So, it cannot be a serious form of communication," says Aditi. Friendly characters communicate the message, even depictions of the female anatomy are done plainly.

Aditi and Tuhin crowd-funded Menstrupedia in 2013, mostly through their NID network. They built it as a business rather than an NGO, because going village to village was not sustainable, and because a business can price for the urban market and then translate, cut costs and distribute free in rural areas. Today, Menstrupedia Comics are used in 37,500 schools, translated in every Indian language. Aditi has something for boys too: Gulu shines a light on male puberty, covering nightfall, masturbation, consent and addiction. As Aditi says, it is our duty to raise our boys right. ■

—Jumana Shah

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Aditi founded Menstrupedia Comics, a friendly, animated guide and digital platform that helps shatter taboos and educates school children about puberty, menstruation and hygiene



MAYUR BHATT